

Cloudflare Tunnel on Kubernetes — ArgoCD GitOps (demo-argo)

Deploy a Cloudflare Tunnel connector (`cloudflared`) into a Kubernetes cluster with **ArgoCD**, so Services are reachable on a public hostname **without exposing any public IP / LoadBalancer**. The tunnel (`demo-argo`) is built manually; ArgoCD manages the in-cluster connector via GitOps.

Architecture

Internet → Cloudflare edge → demo-argo tunnel → cloudflared pods → Service
(DNS: demo-argo.itlinux.cc) (outbound-only) (in cluster) (front:80)

- **No inbound exposure** — `cloudflared` dials *out* to Cloudflare; nothing is opened on the cluster.
- **ArgoCD** continuously reconciles the connector Deployment/ConfigMap to the `argo` branch.
- **Tunnel credentials** live in a Kubernetes Secret created **out-of-band** — never in git.

Repository layout (`argo` branch)

```
manifests/
  cloudflared.yml      # Deployment (2 replicas, HA) + ConfigMap (tunnel: demo-argo)
  kustomization.yaml   # pins the cloudflared image tag (no :latest drift)
argocd/
  application.yaml     # ArgoCD Application CR — points at manifests/
  README-argocd.md     # this document
.gitignore             # keeps credentials.json out of git
```

Prerequisites

- A running Kubernetes cluster with `kubectl` access (EKS, GKE, k3s, ...).
- **ArgoCD** installed in the cluster (namespace `argocd`).
- `cloudflared` CLI on your workstation.
- A domain managed in Cloudflare (this guide uses `demo-argo.itlinux.cc`).

Step 1 — Build the tunnel + credentials Secret (one-time, NOT GitOps-managed)

The `demo-argo` tunnel is created manually. Its `credentials.json` becomes the `cloudflared-credentials` Secret that the Deployment mounts. The ConfigMap's `tunnel: demo-argo` must match this tunnel.

```
cloudflared login          # browser auth — pick the itlinux.cc zone
cloudflared tunnel create demo-argo # writes ~/.cloudflared/<TUNNEL-ID>.json

kubectl create namespace cloudflared

# Load the tunnel creds as the Secret (key name MUST be credentials.json)
TID=$(cloudflared tunnel list --output json \
  | python3 -c "import sys,json;print([t['id'] for t in json.load(sys.stdin) if t['name']=='demo-argo'][0])")
kubectl -n cloudflared create secret generic cloudflared-credentials \
  --from-file=credentials.json="$HOME/.cloudflared/${TID}.json"
```

```
# Route the public hostname to the tunnel (creates the proxied CNAME)
cloudflared tunnel route dns demo-argo demo-argo.itlinux.cc
```

Never commit `credentials.json` . It is the tunnel secret. ArgoCD is configured to ignore this Secret so a sync/prune never deletes or manages it.

Step 2 — The Kubernetes manifest (`manifests/cloudflared.yml`)

```
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: Deployment
metadata:
  name: cloudflared
  labels: { app: cloudflared }
spec:
  selector:
    matchLabels: { app: cloudflared }
  replicas: 2 # HA: 2 connectors share the same tunnel
  template:
    metadata:
      labels: { app: cloudflared }
    spec:
      containers:
        - name: cloudflared
          image: cloudflare/cloudflared:latest # tag pinned via kustomization.yaml
          args: ["tunnel", "--config", "/etc/cloudflared/config.yaml", "run"]
          livenessProbe:
            httpGet: { path: /ready, port: 2000 }
            failureThreshold: 1
            initialDelaySeconds: 10
            periodSeconds: 10
          resources:
            requests: { cpu: 50m, memory: 64Mi }
            limits: { cpu: 200m, memory: 128Mi }
          volumeMounts:
            - { name: config, mountPath: /etc/cloudflared, readOnly: true }
            - { name: creds, mountPath: /etc/cloudflared/creds, readOnly: true }
      volumes:
        - name: creds
          secret: { secretName: cloudflared-credentials }
        - name: config
          configMap:
            name: cloudflared
            items: [{ key: config.yaml, path: config.yaml }]
---
apiVersion: v1
kind: ConfigMap
metadata:
  name: cloudflared
data:
  config.yaml: |
    tunnel: demo-argo
    protocol: http2 # EKS/overlay-CNI safe (avoids QUIC MTU flaps)
    metrics: 0.0.0.0:2000
    no-autoupdate: true
    credentials-file: /etc/cloudflared/creds/credentials.json
    ingress:
      - hostname: "demo-argo.itlinux.cc"
        service: http://front.default.svc.cluster.local:80
      - service: http_status:404
```

`manifests/kustomization.yaml` pins the image so syncs are reproducible:

```

apiVersion: kustomize.config.k8s.io/v1beta1
kind: Kustomization
resources:
- cloudflared.yml
images:
- name: cloudflare/cloudflared
  newTag: "2026.6.1"

```

Step 3 — The ArgoCD Application (`argocd/application.yaml`)

```

apiVersion: argoproj.io/v1alpha1
kind: Application
metadata:
  name: cloudflared
  namespace: argocd
  finalizers:
  - resources-finalizer.argocd.argoproj.io
spec:
  project: default
  source:
    repoURL: https://github.com/itlinux/cloudflare-k8s.git
    targetRevision: argo          # the branch
    path: manifests                # kustomize dir
  destination:
    server: https://kubernetes.default.svc
    namespace: cloudflared
  syncPolicy:
    automated:
      prune: true                 # remove resources deleted from git
      selfHeal: true              # revert manual drift back to git
    syncOptions:
    - CreateNamespace=true
  ignoreDifferences:              # never manage/prune the out-of-band Secret
  - group: ""
    kind: Secret
    name: cloudflared-credentials
    jsonPointers: ["/data"]

```

Step 4 — Register + sync

```

# Register the Application
kubectl apply -f argocd/application.yaml

# ...or via the ArgoCD CLI
argocd app create cloudflared \
  --repo https://github.com/itlinux/cloudflare-k8s.git \
  --revision argo --path manifests \
  --dest-server https://kubernetes.default.svc \
  --dest-namespace cloudflared \
  --sync-policy automated --auto-prune --self-heal \
  --sync-option CreateNamespace=true

# Sync + verify
argocd app sync cloudflared
argocd app get cloudflared
kubectl -n cloudflared logs -l app=cloudflared --tail=20 # "Registered tunnel connection"
curl -I https://demo-argo.itlinux.cc                      # HTTP/2 200

```

How redeployments work (GitOps)

With `automated` + `selfHeal` + `prune`, ArgoCD continuously reconciles the cluster to the `argo` branch:

You do...	ArgoCD does...
Push a manifest change (image tag, ingress, replicas)	Auto-syncs it to the cluster
<code>kubectl edit</code> manual drift	Reverts it back to git state (selfHeal)
Remove a resource from git	Prunes it from the cluster
(anything to <code>cloudflared-credentials</code>)	Ignores it — never managed/pruned

Redeploy = `git push` to `argo`. No manual `kubectl apply` needed.

Troubleshooting

- **Tunnel flaps** (`control stream encountered a failure`, `datagram handler ... context canceled`): QUIC datagrams hitting a reduced MTU on an overlay CNI (Calico VXLAN/IPIP, EKS). Already mitigated by `protocol: http2` in the ConfigMap. After editing, ArgoCD re-syncs; or `kubectl -n cloudflared rollout restart deploy/cloudflared`.
- **no such host / 502 for the origin**: the backend Service named in `ingress` doesn't exist in that namespace. Create it (e.g. `kubectl create deployment front --image=nginx && kubectl expose deployment front --port=80`).
- **Hostname won't resolve**: ensure the DNS route exists — `cloudflared tunnel route dns demo-argo demo-argo.itlinux.cc`.